talk about; they were both intelligent, ambitious people. Indeed, Harkha doesn't exist only as Akbar's bride in history; she is known for her formidable trading business, too. It is also likely that she was a great influence on Akbar – along with the several other Rajput princesses the padishah would marry; that she swayed his thoughts on religion, policy, even diet (Badauni complains that Akbar's Rajput wives made him give up onion and garlic). And, of course, Harkha gave Akbar his first son and eventual heir.

But the chronicles say nothing about love.

It is not necessary, of course, for an emperor to love a wife, but there is something stark about the utter lack of documented romance in Akbar's life, especially given the amorous tendency in his dynasty. It wasn't just Humayun who fell madly in love with Hamida, but Babur with Baburi, Jahangir with Nurjahan, Shahjahan with Mumtaz, and even the allegedly ascetic Aurangzeb with a dancing girl called Hira Bai, for whom the strict believer was willing to down a goblet of wine. All that the records contain of Akbar's feelings for his wives is a lament by the emperor himself. 'Had I been wise earlier,' he once said, 'I would have taken no woman from my own kingdom into my seraglio, for my subjects are to me in the place of children.'[34]

There is a deep sadness in the sentiment, whether he intended it or not; the same sadness that fills his eyes in that painting with the fatherless Abdur Rahim. The young man whose passions overflowed upon the backs of testosterone-fuelled elephants, the nineteen-year-old who jousted with God, could he not – would he not – allow himself to dally awhile in a lover's arms?

There is no account, then, of Akbar's feelings for the 'gentle daughter'[35] of Amber, nor vice versa; but his intense, rewarding and often tempestuous relationships with her less-than-gentle kin spill over the pages. Best known of these new allies are the princess's brother Bhagwant Das and his son Man Singh, both of whom accompanied Harkha to Agra. Within months, Bhagwant Das was riding into battle by Akbar's side. Man Singh, eleven years old at the time, was given a different kind of command, and put in charge of little Abdur Rahim. Such was the bond, it seems, that developed between Man Singh and the boy – both grew up to become Akbar's trusted